

So prioritise your day. Run a quick check of what needs to be completed first, then get down to doing it. Run this check-sweep three times a day to make sure you're on track. Do not procrastinate.

In order to help you prioritise your tasks, learn to slot them into compartments based on importance. Keep the toughest things for the beginning. Avoid doing any unnecessary (and possibly distracting) work—any task not important or related to the goal at hand. An example: you keep going to the water-cooler so as to put off that tough little bit of work, don't you? Don't! Kill the thought by keeping a water bottle with you—an extra-large one, the “2 litres plus 250 ml free” variety—it will save you precious minutes and a lot of distraction.

Many suppose multi-tasking improves productivity, but there's a limit. Joshua Rubinstein, David Meyer and Jeffrey Evans, in *Human Perception and Performance*, in the prestigious *Journal of Experimental Psychology*, showed that as tasks get more complex, our productivity while multi-tasking comes down. See www.livingeffectively.com/public/goals.htm for more.

Our drift all through this has been: focus, focus, *focus*. Just that.

The Devil Of Small Things

Most time-wasters at the workplace are generated by The Computer: you spend most of your time there. Optimise it so you'll get distracted as little as possible.

First turn off all unnecessary pop-up and balloon notifications. (So what if gh_ij just signed in? You're doing your work, right?) If your computer has loads of pop-ups springing up from time to time, run an anti-spyware and anti-adware program to cleanse your computer. Another way to free yourself off the distractions is to get offline! Yes, this is one of the best ways to stay focused on the job at hand. Close down all unnecessary inboxes, IM clients, and close your network connection. If your office environment requires you to be on a messenger client the whole day, learn to leave polite away messages to indicate that you are busy and can't be disturbed unless absolutely necessary. (Yes, go ahead and actually make a customised Away message—you've been putting that off, right?)

Next, it's time to blame the way you use your software. We just don't use some of the nifty features that come with them, so here are some pointers.

- ☑ Keep shortcuts to your most frequently-used programs in the Windows Quick Launch bar.
- ☑ Don't mail things that you can just shout out to the guy sitting next to you.
- ☑ If you have those extra “Internet” or “e-mail” buttons on your keyboard, use them!
- ☑ Use the Help menu in software when you get stuck somewhere. These sections are normally well-documented by software authors. Trying to solve the problem yourself will only get you more distracted.
- ☑ If you are still using Internet Explorer 6 or below, use an alternative browser; Opera has by far the fastest page rendering engine out there.
- ☑ If a particular software keeps trying to open



Educate people around you to keep their mobile phones on vibrator mode!”

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certain filetypes, and that's causing you distractions because you keep doing **File > Open With**, correct the situation by using the File Associations option. Right-clicking on a file, select “Open with”, and select the correct program. Check the “Always use this...” box.

- ☑ Use the tabbed browsing feature in your Web browser; updated versions of all browsers support this feature these days. This way you don't have to wait for a site to load; switch over to the next-most important tab in the meanwhile.
- ☑ If the sites you regularly visit support RSS, use RSS readers instead of going to each site individually.
- ☑ Use the “sessions” feature in browsers like Firefox and Opera. Configure the browser to open up all the sites you visit daily every time you start your browser.
- ☑ Put your frequently accessed folders in the “Favorites” menu. That's what its there for, isn't it?
- ☑ Stop using Windows' inbuilt search; using Google Desktop Search (or a similar piece of software) is much faster. Similarly, install the Google toolbar rather than going to Google.com every time.
- ☑ Whenever you find yourself straining to read what you are seeing on the screen, increase the font size. Keeping the [Ctrl] key pressed and scrolling the mouse wheel up or down will help you increase or decrease the font size in most software.

Software Solutions

There are software that allow you to focus on productivity, a new breed that does away with all the bells and whistles and focuses only on utility and ease of use—by providing you with the bare minimum of tools needed to do the job. If you spend long hours getting your fingertips numb at the keyboard, try out DarkRoom. This is a software that gives you a full-screen text editor. So what's special? Well, it blanks out the entire screen when it is in full-screen mode, and suppresses pop-ups and other notifications, thus ensuring it gets your undivided attention. The Mac variation of this tool is called WriteRoom, and there's a Java-based editor called JdarkRoom if you're working in Linux.

For those of you who like to use personal information management tools, there's TiddlyWiki (which we wrote about in September 2006), which acts as a personal notebook to sort these little tasks into various parts of your day. It is actually a single HTML file that has CSS and JavaScript code incorporated into it. When you download it and start using the file, it overwrites itself based on your preferences when you save any information to it. Every new entry is known as a “Tiddler”—a log of the things waiting to be done on your to-do list. This is saved in the local copy of the TiddlyWiki HTML file for future reference. Existing Tiddlers can be modified or deleted, thus allowing you to sort, tag, and categorise your tasks based on your needs.

Tools like Backpack (backpackit.com) and Thinking Rock are meant to be used online, while those like TurboNote (www.turbonote.com)